Reclaiming Urban Belonging:

Policy Interventions to Reverse Gentrification in Atlanta

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Author Note

This paper is part of an ongoing research project on housing, development, and displacement in the Atlanta region, which also includes a housing and displacement-risk toolkit.

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Abstract

This paper explores the growing impact of gentrification in Atlanta, with a focus on housing affordability, community displacement, and economic equity. Drawing from local data and successful policy models in other U.S. cities, the research evaluates how strategies such as community land trusts, inclusionary zoning, and rent stabilization can help cities reverse the negative consequences of gentrification. By identifying both the causes and potential solutions, the goal is to promote urban development that benefits all residents—especially those most vulnerable to displacement.

Keywords: gentrification, displacement, affordable housing, community land trusts, regional planning, Atlanta

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1. Introduction

Gentrification is no longer a distant or isolated phenomenon—it is now a central force reshaping American cities. In Atlanta, this process has intensified dramatically over the past two decades, transforming entire neighborhoods while pushing out thousands of long-standing residents. Through this research, I aim to uncover both the drivers of this change and the proven policy strategies that cities can use to reverse or soften its impacts. Grounded in data analysis, case studies, and interviews with community leaders, this paper focuses on Atlanta while drawing lessons from cities like Burlington, Washington D.C., and Minneapolis.

2. The Economic Displacement Crisis in Atlanta

2.1 Rising Costs and Shrinking Accessibility

Atlanta ranks among the top U.S. cities experiencing economic displacement. Since 1980, thousands of residents have been priced out of historically working-class neighborhoods, including Old Fourth Ward, Kirkwood, Edgewood, and Grant Park. In Kirkwood, for instance, the total population has shifted significantly, with home prices and rent levels rising sharply over the last two decades. In Edgewood, homes now often sell for over $400,000 as of 2022, compared to prices below $40,000 a generation ago. Median rents in Atlanta climbed to $2,068/month in 2023, a 38% increase from 2018, forcing renters to spend over half their income on housing in many neighborhoods.

These figures come from the datasets and reports used in the original phase of this project, described in Section 4.

This data shows that gentrification is not simply a matter of aesthetic change or economic growth—it is a process that displaces the very communities that shaped these neighborhoods.

The effects are concentrated in BeltLine-adjacent areas such as Reynoldstown and the West End, where public investment in trails and parks has arrived alongside rapid increases in land and home values.

2.2 The BeltLine Premium

The clearest evidence of this pattern comes from peer-reviewed research on the Atlanta BeltLine, a 22-mile loop of trails, parks, and planned transit connecting 45 neighborhoods along former rail corridors (Immergluck & Balan, 2018). Between 2011 and 2015, homes within a half-mile of the BeltLine appreciated 17.9% to 26.6% more than comparable homes elsewhere in the city, depending on the segment (Immergluck & Balan, 2018). The largest premium appeared near the Southwest segment, which runs through lower-income, historically Black neighborhoods.

This matters because rising values affect renters and owners differently. Long-time homeowners may gain equity, but they also face higher property tax assessments. Renters gain nothing from appreciation and face higher rents when leases renew. In Georgia, there is no legal ceiling on those increases, a constraint discussed later in this paper.

2.3 A Policy Response That Has Not Kept Pace

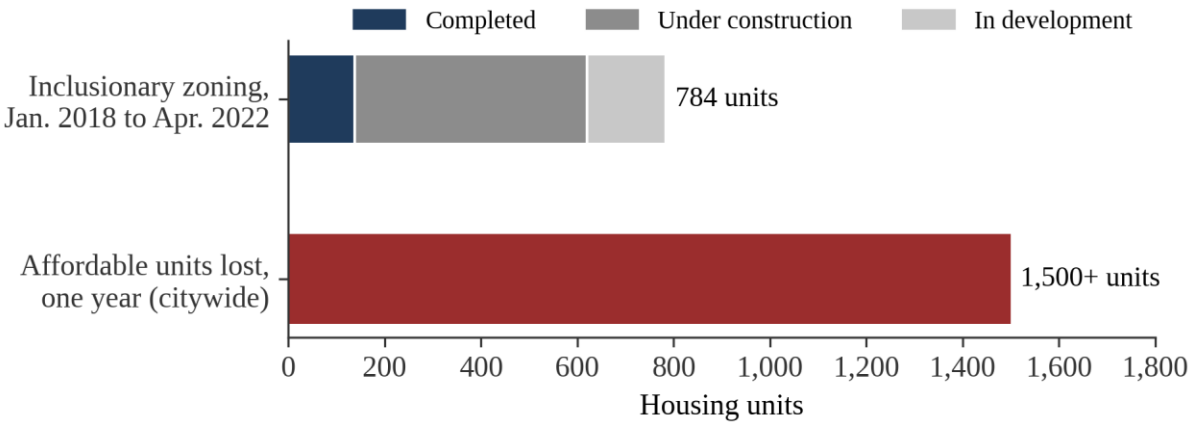
Atlanta has responded, but at a smaller scale than the problem. In January 2018 the city adopted mandatory inclusionary zoning in the BeltLine Overlay District and the Westside neighborhoods near Mercedes-Benz Stadium (City of Atlanta, 2018). New rental projects with 10 or more units must set aside 15% of units for households at or below 80% of area median income (AMI), or 10% at or below 60% AMI, or pay an in-lieu fee (City of Atlanta, 2018).

By spring 2022, the program had produced 138 completed affordable units, with 646 more under construction or in development (Atlanta Civic Circle, 2022). That same analysis

noted that the city loses upwards of 1,500 affordable units per year. Inclusionary zoning is adding affordable homes, but far fewer than the market is removing.

Figure 1

Affordable Units From Inclusionary Zoning Compared With Annual Losses, City of Atlanta



Note. Pipeline counts as of April 2022. Data from Atlanta Civic Circle (2022).

As Figure 1 shows, even counting every unit still in the pipeline, the program's first four years produced about half of what the city loses in a single year.

3. Infrastructure, Transit, and the Geography of Displacement

Displacement in metro Atlanta follows infrastructure. Where public investment makes a place more accessible, land values rise first, and the residents with the least housing security feel it first.

3.1 Prices Move at the Announcement, Not the Ribbon-Cutting

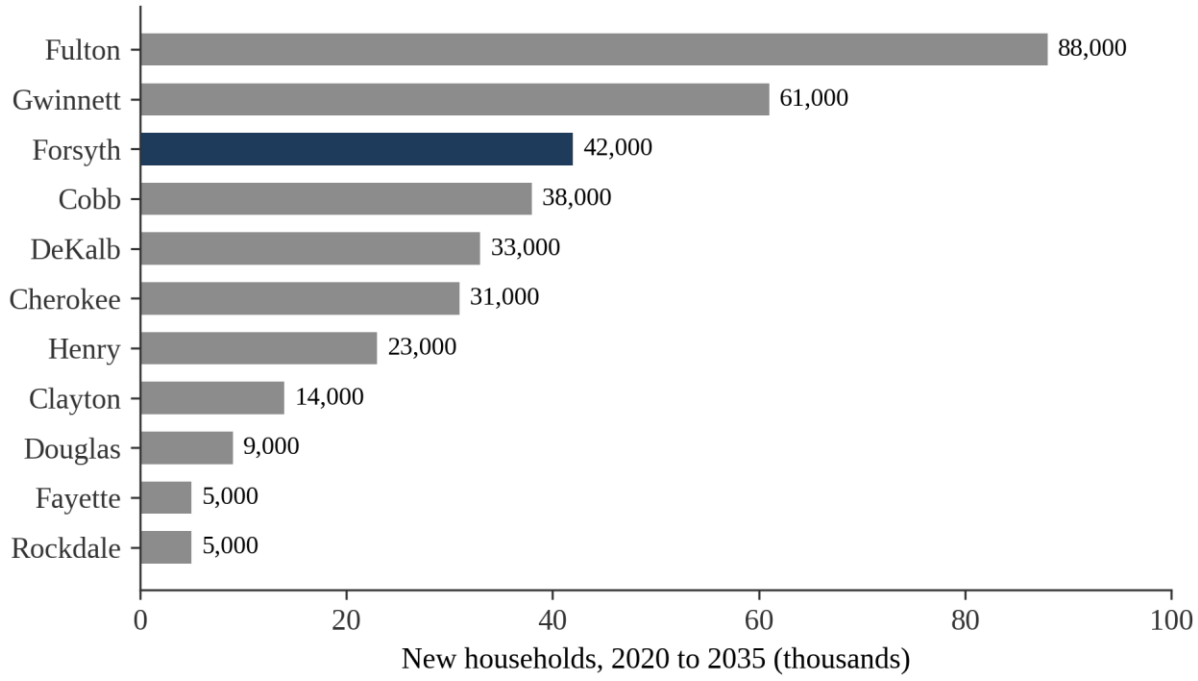
Immergluck (2009) examined home sales from 2000 to 2006 and found large jumps in price premiums near the lower-income, southside sections of the BeltLine between 2003 and 2005. The timing matched early newspaper coverage of the planning process, years before the trails were built. For policy, this means anti-displacement protections need to be in place when a project is announced, not when it opens.

3.2 The Region Is Growing Outward, Away from Transit

The same dynamic now operates at a regional scale. The Atlanta Regional Commission (ARC) forecasts about 350,000 new households across its 11-county region by 2035 (ARC & HR&A Advisors, 2026), as shown in Figure 2.

Figure 2

Forecast Household Growth by County, Atlanta Region, 2020 to 2035



Note. Forsyth County is highlighted. Data from ARC Series 17 forecasts, compiled by HR&A Advisors in the ARC Board meeting packet of March 11, 2026 (ARC & HR&A Advisors, 2026).

Forsyth County, where much of my local government work took place, is forecast to add about 42,000 households, the third-largest increase in the region. Under ARC's current forecasts, 80% of new households in 2035 would face commutes longer than 30 minutes to new jobs, compared with 75% of households today. More than half of new households would live farther than a half-mile from high-capacity transit, even counting planned lines. Meanwhile, some high-opportunity areas would add few homes despite strong job growth: Alpharetta is forecast to

receive 5% of new regional jobs but only 1% of new households (ARC & HR&A Advisors, 2026).

3.3 Displacement Moves Across the Region

This suggests that displacement is not only a neighborhood-level event. It can redistribute housing pressure across an entire metropolitan region. ARC's analysis of 20 counties found that 53% of census tracts experienced at least one major change condition between 2000 and 2019, such as rapid population growth, population loss, or rising poverty concentration (ARC, 2021). ARC links these patterns to three trends: more affluent residents moving into the City of Atlanta, town-center redevelopment and new transportation options producing similar pressure in smaller suburban cities, and lower-income households concentrating in unincorporated suburbs where older housing is cheaper (ARC, 2021). In other words, households priced out of one place carry the pressure somewhere else, often farther from jobs and transit.

3.4 Why This Is a Housing Problem, Not Only a Traffic Problem

When homes near jobs and transit are scarce, households trade lower rent for longer and costlier commutes, and the lowest-income households have the fewest choices. ARC's draft Regional Housing Strategy treats these as one problem. Its growth scenario places new homes affordable below 80% of AMI by weighting three goals equally: nearness to jobs, proximity to transit, and access to high-opportunity areas (ARC & HR&A Advisors, 2026). This framework was presented to the ARC Board at its March 11, 2026 meeting, which I attended as part of the Model Atlanta Regional Commission program.

The lesson for this paper is that transportation and development decisions are housing decisions. A new trail, transit line, or interchange changes who can afford to live nearby, and policy should anticipate that change instead of reacting to it.

4. Methods

This study combines three sources of evidence: quantitative data on housing and development across six Atlanta-area counties, interviews with local officials and housing organizations, and case studies of policy responses in other U.S. cities.

4.1 Quantitative Data

In the original phase of this project, I assembled eleven datasets covering six counties in the Atlanta region to map where gentrification pressure, new development, transit access, and land values overlap. The goal was to find places where rising land values and new infrastructure were arriving in neighborhoods with large shares of renters or lower-income households.

The full paper and data files from that phase were lost before this version was written, so the specific county and dataset list is not reproduced here. Rather than reconstruct it from memory, this version rebuilds the analysis with the public datasets listed in Table 1. They measure the same four pressures, mostly at the census-tract level, across ARC's 11-county region, with closer attention to Forsyth County.

Table 1

Datasets Used in the Continued Analysis (Fall 2026)

Measure	Source	Geography	What it indicates
Median home value	American Community Survey (ACS), via ARC Open Data & Mapping Hub	Census tract	Appreciation and ownership affordability
Median gross rent	ACS 2020–2024 release, via ARC	Census tract	Rent pressure
Rent burden (30%+ of income on housing)	ACS, via ARC	Census tract	Households already under cost pressure
Renter-occupied share	ACS, via ARC	Census tract	Exposure to rent increases
Median household income	ACS, via ARC	Census tract	Ability to absorb rising costs
Residential building permits	ARC annual population and permit estimates	County and city	Where new development is occurring

Measure	Source	Geography	What it indicates
Eviction filing rate	ARC Metro Atlanta Eviction Tracker, with Eviction Lab	Census tract (5 core counties)	Housing instability and possible displacement
Transit proximity	ARC and MARTA transit data	Census tract	Access created by infrastructure
Neighborhood change conditions, 2000–2019	ARC Regional Snapshot (2021)	Census tract	Baseline of past change
Forecast household growth to 2035	ARC Series 17 forecasts, compiled by HR&A Advisors	County	Where future pressure is headed

Note. ACS = American Community Survey; ARC = Atlanta Regional Commission; MARTA = Metropolitan Atlanta Rapid Transit Authority.

4.2 Interviews

I conducted interviews and conversations with district commissioners, including Forsyth County Commissioner Alfred John, and with staff at HouseATL, the Atlanta Land Trust, and other housing-focused nonprofits. These conversations captured what the datasets could not: how residents experience rising costs, what tools organizations actually have, and what constraints local governments face. Findings are summarized in Section 6.

4.3 Case Studies and Regional Plans

I compared Atlanta's current approach with three cities that have used different tools against displacement: Burlington, Vermont (community land trusts), Washington, D.C. (tenant purchase rights), and Minneapolis (zoning reform). I also drew on regional planning materials from the Atlanta Regional Commission, including the draft Regional Housing Strategy presented to the ARC Board in March 2026.

4.4 Continued Research (Fall 2026)

The rebuilt analysis is a fall 2026 continuation of the original project, and it is dated that way on purpose. It has three steps. First, map each indicator in Table 1 by census tract. Second, identify tracts where several pressures overlap: rising rents or home values, a high renter share,

new development or transit investment, and rising eviction filings. Third, test those overlaps against ARC's record of which tracts actually changed between 2000 and 2019.

That third step comes before any scoring. Only indicators that line up with real past change will be used to sort neighborhoods into categories of risk, from emerging pressure to active displacement, in the toolkit that accompanies this paper. ARC's new eviction tracker makes this possible, since it reports filing rates by census tract across Clayton, Cobb, DeKalb, Fulton, and Gwinnett counties (Wright, 2026).

5. Lessons from Other Cities

Each comparison city attacks displacement at a different point: Burlington takes land off the speculative market, Washington, D.C. gives tenants power at the moment of sale, and Minneapolis lowers prices by making more housing legal to build. Only some of these tools are available in Georgia (Table 2).

Table 2

Anti-Displacement Tools in Three Comparison Cities

City	Tool	How it works	Reported result	Available in Georgia?
Burlington, VT	Community land trust	Trust keeps the land; buyers own the home and resell at a capped price	About 600 shared-equity homes and 2,400+ rental units (Shelterforce, 2021)	Yes. The Atlanta Land Trust already operates this model
Washington, D.C.	Tenant Opportunity to Purchase Act (1980)	Tenants get the first chance to buy their building when it is sold, or assign that right to a partner	16,224 affordable units developed or preserved, 2006 to 2020 (CNHED, 2023, as reported)	Would require new law; no Georgia equivalent was found in this research
Minneapolis, MN	Zoning reform (Minneapolis 2040)	Allowed more apartments near transit and corridors, ended parking minimums	Housing stock +12%, rents +1%, 2017 to 2022 (Pew, 2024)	Yes. Zoning is a local power

Note. Data from Shelterforce (2021), CNHED (2023), and Pew Charitable Trusts (2024).

5.1 Burlington: Taking Land Off the Market

The Champlain Housing Trust grew out of two organizations the City of Burlington founded in 1984, and it is now the largest community land trust in the country (Shelterforce, 2021). Homeowners build some equity, but a resale formula keeps each home affordable for the next buyer (Donnelly, 2015). The key lesson is permanence: a subsidy invested once keeps working for every future owner, instead of disappearing at the first sale.

5.2 Washington, D.C.: Power at the Moment of Sale

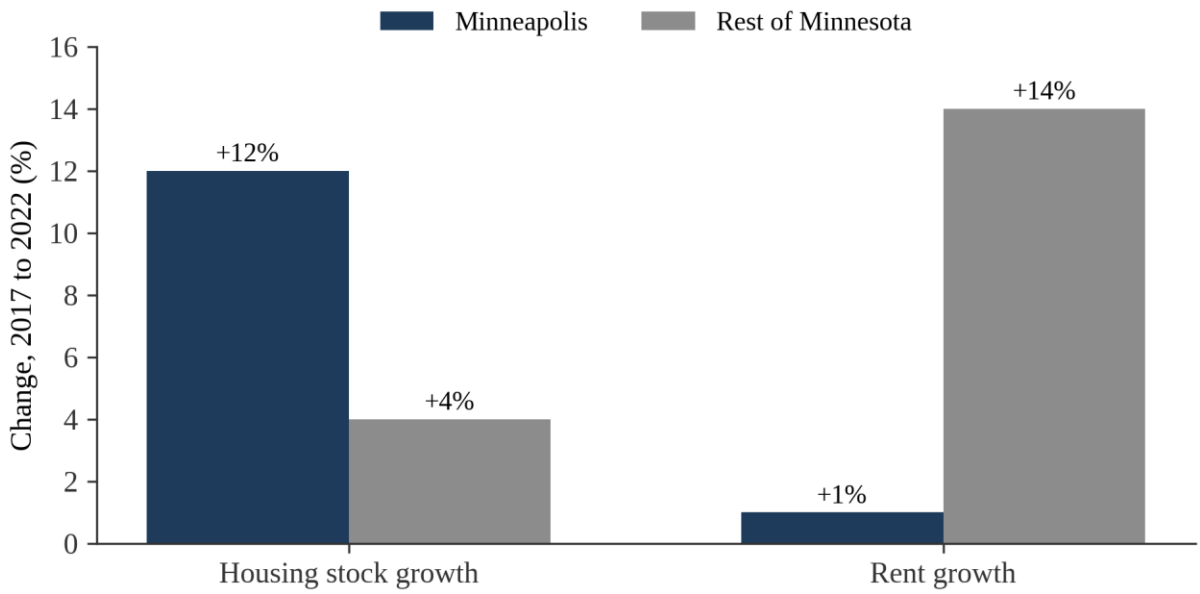
D.C.'s Tenant Opportunity to Purchase Act gives tenants the first opportunity to buy their building when it goes up for sale (D.C. DHCD, n.d.). Tenants can buy it themselves, often as a cooperative, or assign the right to a nonprofit partner committed to affordability. A 2023 study commissioned by the D.C. Council found that 16,224 affordable units were developed or preserved through TOPA from 2006 to 2020 (CNHED, 2023). The lesson is timing: a building sale is when displacement usually happens, so that is where the intervention sits.

5.3 Minneapolis: Adding Supply Where People Want to Live

Minneapolis reformed its zoning to allow more housing, especially apartment buildings near transit and commercial corridors, and eliminated parking mandates. From 2017 to 2022 the city grew its housing stock by 12% while rents rose only 1%, compared with 4% and 14% for the rest of Minnesota (Pew Charitable Trusts, 2024). The widely publicized duplex and triplex change produced only about 1% of new units. Most of the gain came from apartments.

Figure 3

Housing Stock and Rent Growth, Minneapolis and the Rest of Minnesota, 2017 to 2022



Note. Data from Pew Charitable Trusts (2024).

As Figure 3 shows, the comparison reverses between the two measures: Minneapolis grew its housing three times faster than the rest of the state, and its rents grew one-fourteenth as fast.

5.4 What This Means for Georgia

This comparison changed one of my original assumptions. My abstract names rent stabilization as a strategy, but Georgia law prohibits any county or city from regulating rent on privately owned residential property (O.C.G.A. § 44-7-19). The statute does allow local governments to set rents on property they own, or through agreements with private developers (O.C.G.A. § 44-7-19). That means rent limits in Georgia have to be attached to public land, public money, or development deals, which points back toward land trusts and inclusionary requirements.

6. Voices from the Field

The interviews changed the direction of this research: they moved my focus from mapping where displacement happens to asking what changes the incentives that drive it.

6.1 Forsyth County Commissioner Alfred John

I first met Commissioner John through Congressman Rich McCormick's Congressional Youth Advisory Council and at Atlanta Regional Commission Board meetings, and later met with him at his office to discuss future development and housing in Forsyth County. When I presented my research, our conversation shifted my thinking from where displacement happens to what changes the incentives behind it.

Our work together centered on future development and housing in Forsyth County. That setting matters: ARC forecasts that Forsyth will add about 42,000 households by 2035, more than any county except Fulton and Gwinnett (ARC & HR&A Advisors, 2026). In a county growing that quickly, the key questions are not only where change is happening but what shapes it: which projects get approved, what types of homes get built, and what infrastructure comes with them. That is why the conversation turned my attention from mapping outcomes to understanding incentives.

6.2 Atlanta Land Trust

Public context: the Atlanta Land Trust was founded in 2009 and focuses on permanently affordable homes near the BeltLine and in other targeted Atlanta neighborhoods (East Lake Foundation, n.d.). Its Avenue at Oakland City project includes 29 permanently affordable townhomes near a MARTA station and the BeltLine Westside Trail, with prices starting at $186,000 (Atlanta BeltLine, Inc., 2023).

I also spoke with people from the Atlanta Land Trust about how the model works. Community land trusts address a different part of the problem than conventional affordable housing. Instead of attaching a subsidy to one unit for a limited time, the trust keeps the land in long-term community ownership, so affordability carries over to every future sale. That makes land especially valuable to secure in neighborhoods where public investment is about to raise prices, which ties directly to the timing problem the BeltLine research revealed.

6.3 HouseATL and Other Housing Nonprofits

I spoke with people from HouseATL and other housing-focused nonprofits as well. I use three questions to organize what these conversations and the published research show:

1. **Preservation:** How do we stop existing affordable housing from disappearing? Atlanta loses upwards of 1,500 affordable units a year (Atlanta Civic Circle, 2022), which is more than its inclusionary program had produced in total by 2022.
2. **Production:** How do we build homes that lower- and middle-income households can afford? The region is building, but in 2023 about 85% of the City of Atlanta's 7,621 residential permits were for multifamily units (ARC, 2024), and new supply does not automatically reach the households most at risk.
3. **Timing:** How early can communities act before land prices and rents rise? This question connects all three, because the cost of preserving affordability climbs as soon as an investment is announced.

6.4 What the Data Could Not Show

The quantitative analysis could show where housing costs, development, renter concentration, and infrastructure investment overlap. It could not show how residents experience

those changes or why decisions turn out the way they do. The conversations filled that gap by shifting the research from where displacement happens to what changes the incentives behind it.

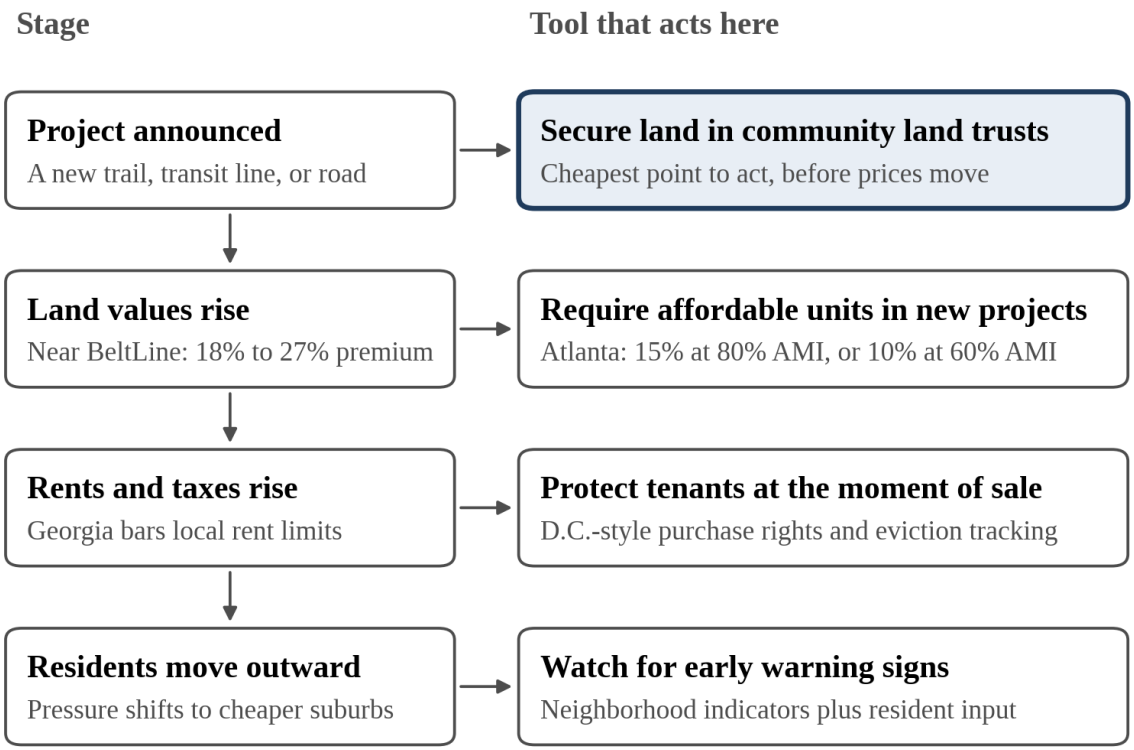
Taken together with the case studies, three points stand out. First, rising land values do not bring stability to renters, who face higher rents with no legal limit in Georgia. Second, the number of affordable units matters less than who can reach them and how long they stay affordable. Third, timing decides cost: once land values and development expectations rise, preserving affordability becomes much harder.

7. Policy Recommendations

Because Georgia bars rent regulation on private property, Atlanta-area governments have to act earlier and through land, zoning, and development agreements rather than through rent caps.

Figure 4

Stages of Displacement and the Policy Tools That Act on Each



Note. The highlighted tool acts at the earliest and least costly stage. Premium range from Immergluck and Balan (2018); inclusionary requirements from City of Atlanta (2018).

The recommendations that follow track the sequence in Figure 4: the earlier a tool acts, the less it costs to keep a home affordable.

1. **Act at the announcement.** When a government announces a major trail, transit line, or interchange, it should trigger anti-displacement tools within a set radius right away, before prices move. The BeltLine showed premiums rising years before construction (Immergluck, 2009).
2. **Scale community land trusts on public land.** Georgia law allows rent limits on publicly owned property (O.C.G.A. § 44-7-19). Placing public parcels into land

trusts, including the underutilized parcels ARC's housing strategy is identifying, creates homes that stay affordable permanently.

3. **Extend inclusionary requirements to where investment is going.** Atlanta's program covers only the BeltLine and Westside districts. Early reports found developers shifting toward for-sale townhomes, which were exempt, and building just outside the overlay (Bisnow, 2019). Requirements should follow major public investment and cover more building types.
4. **Allow more homes near jobs and transit.** Minneapolis kept rents nearly flat by legalizing apartments along transit and commercial corridors (Pew Charitable Trusts, 2024). This matches ARC's goal of placing new households within reach of jobs and transit.
5. **Build an early warning system.** Local leaders need neighborhood-level indicators that combine data with resident input, so they can see displacement risk before it happens. This is the purpose of the housing and displacement-risk toolkit that grows out of this paper.
6. **Study a tenant right of first refusal.** A D.C.-style purchase right would require new legislation in Georgia, but it targets the moment when displacement most often happens: the sale of a building.

8. Limitations

This paper has several limits. The original datasets and county-level results were lost, so this version reports the rebuilt continuation framework rather than the original findings. The interviews were conversations with a small number of officials and organizations, not a representative survey of residents, and detailed notes from them are not quoted here. The

comparison cities operate under different state laws and housing markets than Atlanta. Finally, ARC's 2035 figures are forecasts, and the BeltLine research shows an association with price increases rather than a complete account of every cause.

9. Conclusion

Gentrification in Atlanta is not an accident of the market. It follows public decisions about where to build trails, transit, and roads, and it moves faster than current policy can respond. The BeltLine shows that prices rise at the announcement of an investment, and ARC's forecasts show the same pressures spreading into fast-growing suburban counties like Forsyth.

The tools that work elsewhere point to a clear path for Georgia. Since rent caps are off the table, protection has to come from land held in trust, affordability requirements tied to public investment, more homes near jobs and transit, and better early warning for communities at risk. Reclaiming urban belonging means planning for the people already living in a neighborhood before the investment arrives, not after they have left.

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